# Displaced and devastated

## lives and histories of the indigenous communities

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This worksheet is suitable for classes 9, 10, 11, and 12.

# Identifying indigenous people

Considering the diversity of indigenous peoples, an official definition of "indigenous" has not been adopted by any UN body. Instead, the UN has developed a modern understanding of this term based on the following:

- Self-identification as indigenous peoples at the individual level and accepted by the community as their member.
- Historical continuity with pre-colonial and/or pre-settler societies.
- Strong link to territories and surrounding natural resources.
- Distinct social, economic, or political systems.
- Distinct language, culture, and beliefs.
- Form non-dominant groups of society.
- Resolve to maintain and reproduce their ancestral environments and systems as distinctive peoples and communities.

(Source: https://www.un.org/esa/socdev/unpfii/documents/5session_factsheet1.pdf)

Why has the UN laid down the basis of identification of indigenous people rather than giving an overarching definition?

Despite having ancestral connections with the land, how did these groups become non-dominant?

The following map depicts the spread of indigenous communities currently residing in different parts of the world. Observe it carefully and answer the following questions.

(Source: Julian Burger, United Nations)

Which parts of the world have the least number of indigenous groups? What could the reasons be?

Do you notice any specific patterns of habitation?

# Whose land is it?

The following are a few testimonies of indigenous people living in the deserts of Arizona. Here, the ancestral lands of Apache Native territory are threatened by two of the largest mining companies in the world, Rio Tinto and BHP. The companies have promised economic prosperity for the locals and justified their actions based on the need for copper for electrification of vehicles. However, these lands are considered sacred by the Apache Tribe and they view the environment and resources differently. Read the following excerpts and answer the questions that follow.

*"Understand we're sitting in a holy place, in a sacred place. This is where God touched the world for us with who we are, when it comes to how we protect Mother Earth, not only as a human, but through the spirit of why we have, in Apache, we call them Gaan, but in the English, they call them angels. And those angels live here today. These are corridors that God created for us, and it's no different than parts of the Bible you would find about the beginning. These are real critical places for us and I guess in the White language, our religion," – Dr.Wendsler Nosie Sr., an Apache elder and community leader.*

*"When the United States comes out with their most critical list of important [resources], you find copper, gold, silver, you find all of that, but you don't find water and air. It confuses us because as Indian people, we're like, those are the main two sources that you have to protect, right? But in America, they don't protect it. They don't care.*

*Because as Apache people and as Indigenous people, we're stewards of the land. We have a power to connect, to have these intimate relations with the Earth. And when that's forcefully taken away, not only are we hurting as a people, but these places are hurting, too," – Pike, Nosie's granddaughter.*

(Source: Article by Brando Morin, published in Cultural Survival on May 13, 2024 https://www.culturalsurvival.org/news/apache-stronghold-standing-way-massive-copper-mine)

1. Why do the Apache Tribe call themselves 'stewards of the land'?

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2. Why do these people refer to the United States as 'you' and the Apache Tribe as 'us'?

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3. Think and suggest ways in which the conflict between the companies and the indigenous community can be resolved.

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# 'The Great Australian Silence'

In an article for the ABC News dated October 4, 2023, Kim Huynh wrote:
*In coining the phrase "the Great Australian Silence", Stanner* argued that, despite efforts to forget, downplay, and distance the violence and injustice of British colonialism from Australian history, its effects stuck out "like a foot from a shallow grave". This historical silence needed to be broken, not only as a matter of justice, but because it inhibited all Australians from appreciating the distinctive value of Aboriginal life, culture, and society. Stanner's work in the Northern Territory with Wagiman and Ngan'giwumirri people around the Daly River, and with Murrinh-patha people at Port Keats, was marked by empathy, sophistication, and respect. He took on prevailing attitudes and policies of assimilation which sought to erase the heritage of Aboriginal peoples and to make them "un-be".*

(Source: https://www.abc.net.au/religion/great-australian-silence-weh-stanner-and-the-referendum-debate/102934882)

1. Find out about the history of colonialism in Australia. What do you think is meant by 'historical silence'?

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2. Can you identify any groups around you that have been silenced historically?

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3. Are there any ways in which hitherto silences can be foregrounded in historical research?

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Read the following excerpt from one of Stanner's lectures titled 'Confrontation':
*No English words are good enough to give a sense of the links between an Aboriginal group and its homeland. Our word 'home', warm and suggestive though it may be, does not match the Aboriginal word that means 'camp', 'hearth', 'country', 'everlasting home', 'totem place', 'life source', 'spirit centre' and much else. Our term 'land' is too spare and meagre. We can scarcely use it except without economic overtones unless we happen to be poets.*

(Source: Hinkson, M. & Beckett, J. (Eds.). (2008). *An Appreciation of Difference: W.E.H. Stanner Anthropology and Aboriginal Australia.* Aboriginal Studies Press, p. v)

1. In what ways is the worldview of the indigenous groups different from that of the settlers?

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2. In 2023, a referendum was conducted in Australia to vote on the following proposal: 'To alter the Constitution to recognise the First Peoples of Australia by establishing an Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Voice'. What were its results? Analyze them and write your inferences. Do indigenous voices still differ from the views held by the descendants of settler groups?

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*W.E.H. Stanner (1905-1981) was an Australian anthropologist who raised issues of indigenous groups in Australia and foregrounded white Australia's injustices against Aboriginal people.

## Naming cities, rivers, and lakes: recognition and reconciliation

Find out the origins of the names used for the following cities, rivers, and lakes in Canada:

- Toronto: _____
- Mississauga: _____
- Quebec City: _____
- Athabasca River: _____
- Assiniboine River: _____
- Ottawa River: _____
- Lake Winnipeg: _____
- Lake Ontario: _____

What could the reasons be for naming lakes and rivers after indigenous words or groups?

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Is naming places after indigenous groups enough for reconciliation? Why/why not?

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## Indigenous people in Brazil: extermination and enslavement

*Unlike most of Latin America, Brazil was colonized by the Portuguese. Initial relations with the indigenous population were friendly but colonists eager to exploit trade in wood and sugar soon provoked conflict. The massacres and slavery which almost exterminated the coastal Tupi initiated a pattern repeated over the next 500 years. Rival colonial powers, France and the Netherlands, exploited existing hostilities between indigenous groups. Colonists introduced dysentery, smallpox, influenza and plague. Epidemics of these European diseases swept through the reduções (settlements) instituted by Jesuit missionaries, killing many thousands of indigenous and tribal peoples within a few decades. According to the NGO Survival International, the indigenous population of Brazil is less than 7 per cent of what it was in 1500. It is thought that during pre-colonial times there existed up to 1,000 distinct tribes, while today only an estimated 197 of these remain.*

*In the early nineteenth century, Brazil increased its traditional exports of cotton, sugar and coffee, encroaching still further on indigenous lands. A reported 87 indigenous groups were exterminated in the first half of the twentieth century through contact with expanding colonial frontiers. Between 1964 and 1984 foreign companies and international lending banks tightened control over Brazil's economic structure, continuing to expand the colonizing frontier. Roads stretching across the Amazon basin forced the removal of 25 indigenous groups at the time and the same trends continue. Pressures to expand the Brazilian economy have continued to aggressively erode the Amazon.*

(Source: https://webarchive.archive.unhcr.org/20230518094839/https://www.refworld.org/docid/4954ce5a23.html)

1. Which European powers colonized Brazil?

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2. Why did the colonists import slaves from Africa to work in the plantations?

According to news reports, slavery that was born out of colonization has not ended in Brazil.

*Sugarcane harvesting, which a decade ago was the worst offender in terms of enslaved Indigenous laborers, has now been eclipsed by apple harvesting in the states of Rio Grande do Sul and Santa Catarina, where native peoples endure degrading work conditions.*

3. Why do indigenous people still work under oppressive conditions? List the factors that continue to mire their lives in deprivation and exploitation.

## UN: The threats of climate change

*Indigenous peoples are among the first to face the direct consequences of climate change, due to their dependence upon, and close relationship, with the environment and its resources. Climate change exacerbates the difficulties already faced by indigenous communities including political and economic marginalization, loss of land and resources, human rights violations, discrimination, and unemployment. Examples include:*

*Indigenous peoples in Africa's Kalahari Desert are forced to live around government drilled bores for water and depend on government support for their survival due to rising temperatures, dune expansion and increased wind speeds which have resulted in a loss of vegetation, and negatively impacted traditional cattle and goat farming practices.*

*In the high-altitude regions of the Himalayas, glacial melts affecting hundreds of millions of rural dwellers who depend on the seasonal flow of water is resulting in more water in the short term, but less in the long run as glaciers and snow cover shrink.*

*In the Amazon, the effects of climate change include deforestation and forest fragmentation and consequently, more carbon is released into the atmosphere exacerbating and creating further changes. Droughts in 2005 resulted in fires in the western Amazon region and this is likely to occur again as rainforest is replaced by savannas.*

*In Finland, Norway and Sweden, rain and mild weather during the winter season often prevents reindeer from accessing lichen, which is a vital food source. This has caused massive loss of reindeers, which are vital to the culture, subsistence, and economy of Saami communities.*

(Source: https://www.un.org/)

1. Why do you think the UN considered it important to recognize the impact of climate change on indigenous communities?

2. Find out about the contribution of indigenous communities to greenhouse emissions? Compare it with the contribution of industrialized societies.

3. How do indigenous groups combat climate change? Find out about any two communities that have adopted creative solutions to cope with these changes.

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## Thanksgiving or The National Day of Mourning?

Thanksgiving is a popular American festival that celebrates the three-day harvest feast shared by the English colonists of Plymouth, Massachusetts, and the native Wampanoag people. From the perspective of the colonists, Thanksgiving marks the coming together of two people and the expression of gratitude towards the Wampanoag Native Americans. It also celebrates their survival amidst adverse conditions such as extreme winter, shortage of food and diseases on their arrival in Plymouth. However, Native Americans have a different take on this holiday. Following is an excerpt from an article by Zarafshan Shiraz published in the *Hindustan Times* on November 23, 2023:

*The history from the perspective of Native Americans predates this feast and is overshadowed by colonisation, disease, violence and land theft while marking a moment of interaction between settlers and indigenous people. European settlers, carrying diseases that devastated indigenous populations, made it easier for colonisers to seize lands while instances of warfare, massacres and forced displacement further tainted the relations between settlers and Native Americans. Hence, the Thanksgiving feast, although a diplomatic interaction, is still controversial as some do not consider it as a tradition of warmth and harmony but rather an alliance prompted by mutual defense concerns while the holiday remains contentious due to its historical inaccuracies, cultural appropriation and painful associations for indigenous communities.*
(https://www.hindustantimes.com/lifestyle/festivals/why-did-the-pilgrims-celebrate-the-first-thanksgiving-know-the-complete-story-101700659148623.html)

For many Native Americans, this is a day of protest as it commemorates genocide and oppression by the European settlers. The United American Indians of New England recognized it as the National Day of Mourning.

1. Thanksgiving is a complex holiday in the American historical and contemporary context. What could be done to reconcile varied perspectives?

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## The sacred and the scientific: traditional knowledge

*The Katun Valley contains large numbers of important cultural sites, dating from the Neolithic and representing some of the earliest human settlement in Russia. Modern-day Altaians (the indigenous group inhabiting the region) still observe traditional ceremonies honoring the river and springs throughout the watershed and utilize traditional ecological knowledge in their management of the land and water resources. Russian and international scientists have identified the Altai Mountains as a region of high plant diversity and endemism, and as important habitat for endangered species such as the snow leopard. The Katun River itself contains species of threatened and endangered fishes, … The same regions are considered by the Altaian people to be special or sacred and are recognized by Western scientists as having great value for conservation. During the era of perestroika, a hydroelectric dam was to be built on the Katun. The large dam, would have devastated significant agricultural, ecological, recreational, and cultural resources. The indigenous Altaian people would have lost much of their sacred and cultural landscape. The Katun dam project united indigenous people, well-known Siberian writers, and scientists in protest, which became so heated that it engaged the international community, with lasting*

*effects on Russian society. The magnitude of the protest illustrates the importance of the Altai Mountain region to all of Russia. The active participation of indigenous Altaians reflected their traditional willingness to take action against political decisions that negatively impacted the environmental, cultural, and religious values of their homeland.*

(Source: Klubnikin, K., Annett, C., Cherkasova, M., Shishin, M. and Fotieva, I. (2000). The Sacred and the Scientific: Traditional Ecological Knowledge in Siberian River Conservation, Ecological Applications, 10: 1296-1306, https://www.nps.gov/subjects/tek/russia.htm)

1. Find out about the 'era of perestroika' in Russia and study its stance on indigenous rights.

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2. Think about the nature of 'development projects' such as the construction of dams.

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3. Hydroelectric projects harness renewable sources to generate electricity. Do you think they contribute to the wellbeing of all sections of the society? Why/why not?

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4. What does the excerpt indicate about the significance of pressure groups and protest movements in ensuring the rights of indigenous groups?

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5. Do you think indigenous protests prove detrimental to the course of economic development? Why/why not?

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## The 'Criminal Tribes' of India

*The British colonial administration in India marked out certain communities as 'criminal' by passing the Criminal Tribes Act (CTA) in 1871 (final version enacted in 1924). A slim, sickle-shaped knife hidden between the lower jaw and the cheek, the presence of scattered bajra grains on the floor of a burgled house, false coins secreted in the inner front flap of the loincloth – these are just a few details colonial-era policemen were expected to remember when they were in pursuit of criminal tribes, in order to identify them correctly.*

*The manuals contained much advice on how a proper 'search' should be conducted. M.Paupa Rao Naidu's manual specified that goods looted by the Bhamptas could be concealed within double-built walls, between beams or under the hearth in their homes. Bhampta men often secreted a curved knife in the hollow between the lower jaw and the cheek, which was used as an aid in railway thefts; Gunthorpe explained that to enable this, the gums were hardened by placing a lump of salt there day and night for some time. Body searches too needed to be thorough. The manuals were circulated throughout British India, the authors quoted each other to justify their conclusions and their contents would have been reproduced in many later texts. Thus, prejudice against the 'criminal tribes' proved to be surprisingly enduring as it circulated widely throughout the subcontinent.*

(Source: Article by KrishnokoliHazra, December 6, 2022, https://theprint.in/opinion/british-didnt-just-introduce-criminal-tribes-they-also-had-a-police-manual-on-how-to-abuse/1250489/)

1. Why were tribes in colonial India categorized as 'criminal'?

2. Do you think prejudices against tribes persist in India after more than 75 years of independence from colonial rule? Find out.

3. British officials took several photographs of Indian tribes and castes. Why would colonial officers take photographs of the indigenous people and document them?

## National reserves and wildlife conservation: at what cost?

*Since the establishment of Yellowstone National Park in 1872, there has been a growing movement among conservationists to designate large parcels of the earth as national parks or reserves. Concern over the disappearance of landscapes and wildlife fuels this worldwide movement. With thousands of endangered species listed in the International Union for the Conservation of Nature's (IUCN) Red Data Book, there is good reason to call for the protection of such creatures as the Bengal tiger or the Black rhino. Often, refuges are successful in saving such animals from extinction. Unfortunately, however, the worldwide conservation movement has rarely examined the impact of park development on indigenous peoples. "The creation of national parks has incurred restrictions on the rights of local human populations without compensatory actions on the part of the government."*

*The Tenth General Assembly of the IUCN in New Delhi defined the term "national park" as "a relatively large area where the highest competent authority of the country has taken steps to prevent or eliminate as soon as possible exploitation or occupation in the whole area". This stipulation confirms what has been common practice in launching new national parks. Such areas are cleared of human occupation. The IUCN and other conservation organizations have only recently begun to take into account the needs of those peoples occupying these pristine lands. Wildlife biologists, however, recognize the important niche man has filled in many ecosystems, most of which have been moulded for thousands of years by interaction between man and his environment.*

(Source: https://www.culturalsurvival.org/)

1. Why has the impact of demarcating national reserves on indigenous people rarely been examined?

2. Find out the following information about the tribe that inhabits the area designated as the Maasai Mara National Reserve.
   - The tribe's name
   - Its traditional practices
   - History of encounter with Europeans
   - The tribe's experiences with a rapidly expanding tourism industry

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